

Discourse on the Establishment of Awareness — Satipaṭṭhāna Sutta (MN 10)

Bhante Bodhidhamma · YouTube Talks · 21:12

Greetings. I trust you've had a fruitful day. I do not say happy, though I hope it has been happy.

*Namo Tassa Bhagavato Arahato Sammāsbuddhassa, Namō Tassa Bhagavato Arahato
Sammāsbuddhassa*

So we're making our way through the discourse on right mindfulness. We'll see how far we get this evening. Don't want to rush it, but remember this is only a quick introduction and there are many studies now that you can follow if you wish.

We talked about the body and the breath yesterday, and there's a refrain that comes after every section. It says: "In this way he abides contemplating the body as body" — and it really should be "body in the body" — "internally, and abides contemplating the body in the body externally." That's a bit more difficult. It's really recognising the breath in other people. So we've talked about that, I think. "Or else he abides both the rising and falling factors." So this is beginning to understand the impermanence of the breath. And then finally, he establishes just this mindfulness, just this direct, clear comprehension of what's happening. So that just enough intuitive intelligence and mindfulness is there for insight to arise. And that just comes with practice. You just keep practising.

"And he abides independent, not clinging to anything in the world." So by taking the position of the observer within ourselves, we've left the world as it were. We transcended it. We found a different relationship with it. We don't want to be concerned with it as somewhere where we're going to find any permanent happiness or try to escape the natural pains of living. And so he abides contemplating the body in the body or as the body, whatever you prefer.

Now, the next section is the four postures. It's very simply stated. When you're walking, you understand "I am walking." So in other words, you're aware of walking. And the same with standing and sitting and lying down. So those postures relate mainly to meditation practice. That lying down one, it came up this afternoon in a discussion. It's difficult to do that because as soon as you lie the body down, there's no physical energy supporting your mindfulness. And therefore, of course, there's a tendency just to fall asleep and there's not so much to be gained in oblivion.

There is one way — for those of you who weren't there this morning — a little trick that people use to keep awake if they're doing the lying meditation is to keep your hand up like this. And every time you fall

asleep, the hand drops. And that wakes you up. And if you put something just under your elbow so that you don't hit the funny bone, after a while, it just stays there. The body learns how to just keep your hand there, just as it learned. If you're ill, although actually when you're ill, it's more common to practise *mettā*, loving kindness towards the body.

And there's always this "externally, internally and externally" — in other words recognising this in ourselves but also recognising it in other people. And that gives you this connection. If you remember when the Buddha was fully liberated, he had these two insights: how he had come there by his moral ethical actions — and it was that line of ethical actions rebirth after rebirth that led to his liberation — and he saw the beings also moving from realm to realm dependent on their moral and ethical actions. So what was personal becomes a universal law. What is personal for us becomes universal when you see other people behaving or acting in the same way, having the same experiences, similar experiences.

And then, of course, there's a whole section here about daily life practice. So, again, one acts in full awareness going forward, coming backwards, returning. One acts in full awareness when looking ahead or looking away, when flexing and extending one's limbs. When wearing — well here, of course, it's directed to the monks — but wearing one's clothes, one acts in full awareness when eating, drinking, consuming food and tasting. That's one that's devoted entirely to the whole process of eating. One acts in full awareness defecating and urinating — so you don't forget, that's very important. And then acts in full awareness walking, standing, sitting, falling asleep and waking up, talking and keeping silent.

So in other words, this mindfulness we should carry with us throughout the day as best we can. How do we know we're being mindful? We're being mindful when we're being deliberate, when you are doing what you meant to do. If you're doing something and the mind's wandering — take a simple example: if you're washing the pots and you're thinking about where you're going to go for your holidays — then there's a split. You're not being mindful about what you're doing so the pots don't get washed so well or you drop one or whatever. But as soon as you wake up from that little fantasy, then you can decide: are you going to stop and think about your holiday or you're going to keep washing the pots? So you keep washing the pots. So this mindfulness is just being with what you're doing.

I remember because the Mahāsi technique — everything's very slow. People were much confused about daily life. Did you have to go very slow in order to be mindful? Now, luckily I'd begun with Zen at Throssel Hole Abbey in Northumberland. And there you did — we used to do everything at speed. It wasn't slow, you did everything very, very fast. And the idea was that you built up energy while you were doing this, working, cleaning or out in the gardens. And because you were working fast you had to keep your mind on it or else you'd stump your foot, you'd cut yourself, you'd do something silly. And when you sat of course that energy and focus stayed with you. That's one reason why the Zen I was doing didn't have a particular focus because you could maintain just that attention, just feeling, observing things that came into your mind. We didn't sit that long — forty minutes.

So I didn't have that problem, really. But people who were just doing the *Vipassanā*, just doing the Mahāsi, there was this constant question: "Well, how do you keep mindfulness? You have to go very, very slow." And I remember my teacher, *Sayādaw* Janaka, he'd pick up a pencil that was lying there, he'd pick it up and then he'd put it down. That was it, really. That was a demonstration of mindfulness in action.

So don't mystify it. It's just being with what you're doing. Being your doing is a way to put it. And then, of course, the usual refrain: to be aware of what you're doing, to begin to recognise that things are finished, especially finished. We're very much aware of beginning something, starting something. Because that tends to be new, it tends to be renewal, a rebirthing moment after moment. But we're not so much aware of things ending. Before something ends, we're on to something else. The ending — all ends, remember, are mini deaths. And so we tend to shy off and we tend to leap beyond that to the next thing to be done.

And then, of course, one can have insights, peeling a banana, having a cup of tea. Insights don't come just when you're sitting. In fact, in the Mahāsi tradition, it's well known that it's when you're not sitting that you're more likely to have an insight because often when you're sitting, you're trying, you're trying to get an insight, you're trying to do something. And then when you get up from the seat, because you've got that mindfulness and concentration and you've given up trying to see something or understand something, suddenly there is a seeing of impermanence or not-self. Or just that process of creating suffering for ourselves through wrong desire. So mindfulness in action can bring about the same insights as in meditation.

Now, the next one — let's just keep an eye on the time here, that's good — the next one is rather interesting. It's translated as "the foulness of the body parts." I'll just read it through so that the Buddha is not shy of the body. "And he reviews the same body up and down from the soles of the feet, down from the top of the hair, bounded by skin and full of many kinds of impurities. In the body: head hairs, body hairs, nails, teeth, skin, flesh, sinews, bones, bone marrow, kidneys, heart, liver, diaphragm, spleen, lungs, large intestines, small intestines, contents of the stomach, faeces, bile, phlegm, pus, blood, sweat, fat, tears, grease, spittle, snot, oil of the joints and urine."

That's a good list, isn't it? What intrigues me actually about this list is that the brain isn't included. That was a later addition. I don't know whether the ancients knew what the brain was or what it was for. Because, of course, when it drops out of somebody's head, it's just this lump of fat, isn't it?

And then he gives an example. Now, this example really tells us what the attitude really is. It's unfortunate that people use the word "disgust" or "foulness." "But just as there were a bag with an opening at both ends full of many sorts of grains such as hill rice, red rice, beans, peas, millet and white rice, and a man with good eyes were to open it and review it thus: 'This is hill rice, this is red rice, this is beans, this is peas, this is millet and this is white rice,' so a *bhikkhu* reviews the same body full of impurities."

Now there was a moment where the Buddha obviously gave a very inspiring speech about this, about the body, looking at the body like this, and he must have got across to these monks, to really look upon the

body as something that is not to be indulged — their senses weren't to be indulged. But somehow they got the wrong message. And so what happened was: "And he talked to the *bhikkhus* in many ways on the subject of impurity. He spoke in praise of what is impure. He spoke in praise of the contemplation of what is impure. He spoke again and again in praise of the stage of meditation of what is impure."

"And then the *bhikkhus* went away to meditate. Now they dwelt intent upon the practice of contemplating what is impure in different ways. They were troubled in their own bodies, ashamed of them, loathing them. And as if — and then he goes on — it is as if a woman or man, when young or delicate and fond of dressing, having washed their hair, would be troubled, ashamed and full of loathing because they had a corpse of a snake or of a dog or of a man hung around their neck. Now, so these *bhikkhus*, being troubled by their own bodies, ashamed of them and loathing them, by themselves, deprived themselves of life and deprived each other of life."

So they actually killed each other and killed themselves. Now, when this came back to the Buddha, of course, he must have been — well, it says here that he's extremely angry with them. He must have been, shall we say, very forthright. "*Bhikkhus*, it is not suitable for *bhikkhus*. It is not fit. It is not proper. It is not worthy of a disciple. It is not good. It should not be done." — killing each other, that is.

And then he says, "Whatever *bhikkhu*..." and then he makes a rule, which is the third rule, I think. Yes, the third rule, the *Pārājika*, the defeat rule, whereby if you break the rule, you've lost your robes — you're no longer in communion, that's how it's put. "Whatever *bhikkhu* intentionally deprives a human being of life or seeks to be the knife bearer, he is defeated, he is not one in the community." And there's also encouraging somebody to commit suicide — that's also included in being a knife bearer. So it becomes a third major rule for monks after that.

And then, of course, Ānanda says to the Buddha, "It would be a good thing, Lord, if you would explain in another way, so the community of *bhikkhus* might establish their knowledge." And of course, he does do that.

Now, interestingly enough, the word that's often translated as "disgust" is *nibbidā*. But *nibbidā* really ought to be translated as "disenchantment," a disinterest. So the whole idea is that you balance the pleasures of the body with the displeasures, with the things that are unpleasant. And that way you get a balanced view of your body. When it comes to lust, erotic feelings that have become obsessive, to become lustful, when one actually makes that body go to the toilet, and that definitely undermines the lust. But you're not supposed to then feel disgusted of the object of your lust — you're just supposed to be able to counteract that lustfulness that's grown in you. So it's a balancing act.

But of course the body is also a precious vehicle. The Buddha is clear about that. This is a precious life form and we ought to care for the body. He's often talking about the need for health for the body in order to meditate. So one has to be careful with this.

Now there was one incident — I've been trying to find it but I've been unable to do so — where the monks have been practising this contemplation on the parts of the body that we dislike or we sometimes find disgusting. And he sees that they've created some form of non-attachment to the body. But there's something missing. And what he does is he teaches them loving kindness. And according to the tale, they all become fully liberated. So there's the balance really: to respect the body, care for the body, the need for the body. But we're always trying not to get caught up in its sensuality and not be attached to our sense pleasures, but to recognise that they arise and pass away. And that allows us to enjoy things without that stickiness, without wanting more, more, more. So that's the purpose of the meditation on the body.

And as usual, he abides contemplating internally — one's own body — another person's body. And in that way, they abide independent. That's the nice word. Independent, not clinging to anything in the world.

I think we can stop there because the next bit now takes a little bit more. I ought to spend a bit more time on that because that's the elements. So I hope that's a little bit just to go on with. It's something you can practise by yourself. It's not a big deal. Just recognising the parts of the body that we don't normally like. So there's a sense of disgust for parts of the body — and then is that necessary? Can you live, can you just see what the disgusting parts of the body is — just a necessary function, chemicals? Change your view of it.

Then there's the body beautiful — expecting the body to be beautiful and that often has an effect upon our self-esteem. Just remind ourselves it's an organism and it has a job to do and it's making me see things and hear things. It carries me here and there, it lifts things for me. So it's a case of bringing ourselves off this idea that you have to be beautiful to be happy.

And the third one is to recognise or to contemplate: what is it that we most fear loss of? Going blind or going deaf or paralysis. The loss of functions in the body creates a lot of fear for us. And by bringing those to mind and to accept that, to accept our attachment to these things... And of course, we know from people who do have disabilities that it doesn't have to undermine the quality of your life. But moving from an able person to a disabled person is traumatic. It's a sort of death. But once you get there and arrive, then you accept things as they are.

So these contemplations are there to find a different relationship to the body and that relationship is to be disenchanted with it, not to be caught up in it, but to see it as a precious vehicle through which we are trying to become fully liberated from suffering.

So I can only hope my words will in fact lead you to the liberation from suffering sooner rather than later, so we can begin our contemplation, our meditation.

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